

Table 6.1.10 : Population by Ethnic Group, 1911 - 2024 (in Thousands)

Ethnic group	Census Year										
	1911	1921 ⁽⁴⁾	1931 ⁽⁵⁾	1946	1953	1963	1971	1981	2001 ⁽³⁾	2012	2024
Sri Lanka	4,106.4	4,498.6	5,306.0	6,657.3	8,097.9	10,582.0	12,689.9	14,846.8	16,929.7	20,359.4	21,781.8
Low Country Sinhalese	1,716.9	1,927.1	2,216.2	2,902.5	3,469.5	4,470.3	5,425.8	10,979.4 ⁽²⁾	13,876.2 ⁽²⁾	15,250.1 ⁽²⁾	16,144.0 ⁽²⁾
Up-country (Kandyan) Sinhalese	998.6	1,089.1	1,256.8	1,718.0	2,147.2	3,042.6	3,705.5				
Sri Lanka Tamil	528.0	517.3	598.9	733.7	884.7	1,164.7	1,424.0	1,886.9	732.1	2,269.1	2,681.6
Indian Tamil	531.0	602.7	818.5	780.6	974.1	1,123.0	1,174.9	818.7	855.0	839.5	600.4 ⁽⁶⁾
Sri Lanka Muslim	233.9	251.9	289.6	373.6	464.0	626.8	828.3	1,046.9	1,339.3	1,892.6	2,283.2
Indian Muslim	32.7	33.0	36.3	35.6	47.5	55.4	27.4	(1)	(1)	(1)	(1)
European	7.6	8.1	9.2	5.4	6.5	(1)	(1)	(1)	(1)	(1)	(1)
Burgher & Eurasian	26.7	29.4	32.3	41.9	46.0	45.9	45.4	39.4 ⁷	35.3 ⁷	38.2 ⁷	31.7 ⁷
Malay	13.0	13.4	16.0	22.5	25.4	33.4	43.5	47.0	54.8	44.1	26.6
Sri Lanka Chetty	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	10.8	5.6	2.4
Bharatha	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	2.2	1.7	1.1
Veddas	5.3	4.5	5.2	2.4	0.8	0.4	(1)	(1)	(1)	(1)	1.3
Other	12.7	22.0	27.4	41.1	32.2	19.5	15.5	28.4	23.9	18.2	9.1

Information for the years 2012 and 2024 is presented based on data from the Census of Population and Housing, while data for previous years have been obtained from Statistical Abstracts.

(1) Included under the "Other" category.

(2) Low Country and Up-country Sinhalese have been combined.

(3) Data for 2001 are provided only for the 18 districts where the Census of Population and Housing was fully conducted.

(4) Estimated based on the 1921 Census.

(5) Includes 442 persons whose sex and ethnic group were not reported during the incomplete census of 1931.

(6) Indian Tamil has been referred to as "Malaiyaga Thamilar"

(7) Since 1981 only Burghers are included instead "Burgher & Eurasian" category.